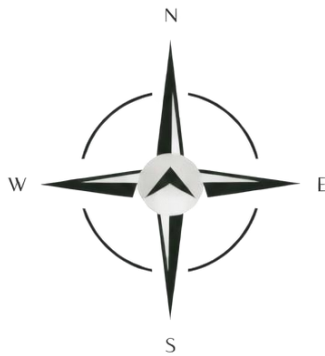




OUTBOUND

TRAVEL PLANNING • EST. 2026

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THE INDONESIA GUIDE

A practical guide to planning a better trip

2026 EDITION

OUTBOUND.

Travel planning, rethought.

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01 — INDONESIA, DONE PROPERLY

Indonesia is not one destination. It is thousands of islands spread across a huge area, with completely different landscapes, cultures and experiences depending on where you go. You can spend one trip exploring temples and volcanoes in Java, another travelling through Bali's rice terraces and beaches, or build an adventure around Lombok and Komodo. The biggest mistake is assuming that because these places are all called Indonesia, they are automatically easy to combine.

The best Indonesia trips begin with a simple question: **what do you actually want from the country?** If you want temples, food and culture, Java and Bali can provide more than enough. If you want beaches and relaxed island life, Lombok and the Gilis may deserve more of the trip. If wildlife, snorkelling and dramatic scenery are

the priority, Komodo can become the centrepiece. If you want everything, you'll need considerably more time than most first-time visitors realise.

Indonesia rewards choosing a **small number of experiences and building around them**. A two-week trip does not need to include Bali, Java, Lombok, the Gilis and Komodo. It might be much better as Bali plus Lombok, or Java plus Bali, or Bali plus Komodo. The fewer major moves you make, the more time you have to actually experience each place.

Bali is often the easiest starting point because it combines beaches, culture, food, nightlife, nature and a huge range of accommodation in one relatively accessible destination. But that convenience can also become its weakness. Trying to see every part of Bali in a few days can turn the trip into a sequence of traffic jams and hotel changes. The same principle applies elsewhere in Indonesia: **being able to get somewhere doesn't necessarily mean it belongs on your route**.

The most useful way to think about Indonesia is by **experience rather than island**. Bali can provide culture, food and beaches. Java can provide volcanoes, temples and a stronger sense of traditional Javanese culture. Lombok can provide quieter beaches, surfing and mountain adventure. The Gilis can provide a deliberately slower island escape. Komodo can provide one of the country's most distinctive combinations of wildlife, islands and marine life.

The result is that there is no single “best Indonesia itinerary”. There is only the best itinerary **for the type of trip you want**.

A seven-day trip should be focused. Ten days gives you enough time to combine two major experiences. Two weeks allows a more ambitious route, while three weeks gives you enough space to travel between several islands without every other day becoming a transfer day.

There is also a different rhythm to Indonesia compared with mainland Southeast Asia. Moving between islands can involve flights, ferries, fast boats, airport transfers and weather-dependent journeys. Every additional island therefore comes with a real logistical cost. The route may look simple on a map, but the actual journey can consume much more of your day than expected.

OUTBOUND RULE: Don't count islands. Count experiences.

If two destinations give you essentially the same type of holiday, choose one and spend the extra time there. If a destination gives you something completely different — a volcano, a major cultural experience, world-class diving or a genuinely different landscape — it has a much stronger case for earning its place.

Indonesia is at its best when the itinerary has **contrast without chaos**: perhaps temples followed by beaches, mountains followed by islands, or busy Bali followed by the slower pace of Lombok.

You don't need to see Indonesia. **You need to choose the part of Indonesia that makes you want to go.**

OUTBOUND. Fewer places. Better trips.

02 — BEFORE YOU GO

Indonesia is one of those countries where **planning around the weather matters**, but not because there is one perfect season for the whole country. Conditions vary between islands, altitude makes a major difference, and tropical weather can change quickly. The most useful approach is to plan around the regions you actually want to visit rather than searching for a single “best month for Indonesia”.

For Bali, Lombok, the Gilis and Komodo, the **drier period is generally around April to October**, with July and August among the busiest months. The wetter period usually falls around November to March. That does not mean travel is impossible during the wet season, but you should expect more humidity, heavier showers and a greater chance of disruption to outdoor plans and boat journeys.

Java follows a broadly similar seasonal pattern, although mountain areas can be much cooler, especially before sunrise. If you're planning Bromo, Ijen or another high-altitude experience, don't pack purely for tropical heat. Early mornings can feel surprisingly cold compared with the coast.

The key point is that **weather should shape the route, not control it completely**. A beach-heavy trip in the wetter months may need more flexibility than a cultural trip focused on Ubud and Yogyakarta. Likewise, if Komodo or a multi-day boat trip is one of the main reasons you're visiting, it makes sense to give weather and sea conditions more weight.

Period	Bali / Lombok	Java	Komodo	OUTBOUND view
Jan–Mar	Wetter, humid	Wetter	Wetter / more variable	Best for flexible travellers
Apr–Jun	Drier, warm	Good	Strong period	Excellent balance
Jul–Aug	Dry, busiest	Dry, cooler at altitude	Popular	Great weather, more crowds
Sep–Oct	Dry to transitional	Generally good	Strong	One of the best overall windows
Nov–Dec	Wetter begins	Wetter	More variable	Good if you accept some rain

Before booking flights, check the **current entry requirements for your passport**. Indonesia's visa and arrival rules can change, and the process may differ depending on nationality, length of stay and how you enter. Use official Indonesian immigration information when you travel rather than relying on a screenshot or an old blog post.

You should also check whether you need to complete any **electronic arrival or customs forms** before landing. These systems can change over time, so treat them as something to confirm shortly before departure rather than information you memorise months in advance.

Money is straightforward in most tourist areas. The local currency is the **Indonesian rupiah (IDR)**. Cards are widely accepted in hotels, larger restaurants and more developed parts of Bali, but cash remains useful for smaller businesses, local transport, markets and more remote areas. ATMs are common in major destinations, but don't assume you'll always find one easily on smaller islands or during long travel days.

Indonesia is also a country where **transport planning matters more than it first appears**. A journey that looks short on the map can involve traffic, port delays, boat transfers and long waits. Build this into your itinerary before deciding how many places to visit. The hidden cost of moving is one of the biggest reasons travellers end up feeling rushed.

Scooters deserve particular caution. They are extremely common in Bali, Lombok and other islands, but that does not make them automatically safe or legally appropriate for every traveller. Road conditions, traffic, weather and licensing requirements all matter. If you don't have proper experience, the correct licence and insurance cover, use a driver or another form of transport instead.

For Komodo, diving, trekking, volcanoes and other adventure activities, check your **travel insurance** carefully. Don't assume a standard policy covers every activity simply because it is commonly sold to tourists.

Health preparation should be practical rather than excessive. Pack any regular medication you need, bring basic sun protection, stay hydrated and be cautious with food and water if something looks questionable. If you are planning remote travel, talk to an appropriate medical professional before departure about whether any vaccinations or additional precautions are recommended for your route.

Another thing to think about is **religious and cultural context**. Bali is predominantly Hindu, while most of Indonesia is predominantly Muslim. Dress and behaviour that feel normal in a resort area may be less appropriate at temples, villages or religious sites. Carrying something lightweight to cover shoulders or knees can be useful, and following local guidance is usually straightforward.

Public holidays and festivals can also affect transport, accommodation and opening hours. Major events can make certain areas much busier, so if your dates overlap with an important national or religious holiday, check what that means for your route before booking tight connections.

The best thing to prepare before you leave is not a minute-by-minute plan. It is a **clear structure**: where you want to start, which two or three experiences matter most, how you're moving between them and where you can afford to be flexible.

OUTBOUND TIP: Indonesia is the kind of place where one extra transfer can easily cost more time than expected. Before adding another island, ask whether that move gives you a genuinely different experience or just another beach.

03 — BUILD YOUR ROUTE

Indonesia is where **good route planning makes the biggest difference**. Unlike travelling through mainland Southeast Asia, moving between Indonesian destinations often means combining flights, ferries, fast boats and road transfers. A destination that looks close on a map can still consume most of a day.

Start by deciding what you want the trip to feel like. If you want culture and food, Bali and Java can provide more than enough. If adventure is the priority, Java's volcanoes or Lombok's Mount Rinjani may deserve the focus. If you want beaches and island life, Lombok and the Gilis are natural choices. If wildlife, snorkelling and dramatic landscapes are the priority, Komodo can become the centrepiece.

For most first-time travellers, **two or three major areas is enough for a 10–14 day trip**. A week should usually focus on one or two areas, while three weeks gives you enough time to add another island without turning the entire holiday into a sequence of transfers.

Trip length	Recommended major bases	Best approach
5–7 days	1–2	Focus on one island/region
8–10 days	2–3	Combine complementary experiences
11–14 days	3–4	Classic multi-region trip
15–21 days	4–5	Add Java, Komodo or deeper island time
3+ weeks	5+	Travel more slowly and selectively

These are deliberately conservative numbers. Indonesia makes it very easy to keep adding destinations because flights and boats can make the distances look manageable. The problem is that every move has a hidden cost: packing, checking out, getting to a port or airport, waiting, travelling, transferring again and finding your accommodation.

CHOOSE YOUR CORE

For a first trip, think of Indonesia in terms of **five core experiences**.

Bali is the all-rounder. It gives you culture, temples, food, rice terraces, beaches, nightlife and a huge range of accommodation. It is the easiest place to build a varied first trip around.

Java is the choice for volcanoes, major temples, cities and a stronger focus on Indonesian culture. Yogyakarta, Borobudur, Prambanan and the volcanic landscapes around Bromo make it substantially different from Bali.

Lombok and the Gilis are the choice for beaches, surfing, diving, island life and a slower pace. Lombok can also become an adventure-focused trip in its own right if Mount Rinjani is a priority.

Komodo is the specialist choice. The combination of Komodo dragons, dramatic islands, snorkelling and boat travel gives you something that the other destinations cannot replicate.

The important thing is that **you don't need all five**.

A two-week trip containing Bali, Java, Lombok, the Gilis and Komodo may sound impressive, but you'll spend a significant proportion of it moving between them. A two-week trip built around Bali and Lombok can feel far more relaxed while still giving you enormous variety.

THE THREE-NIGHT RULE

As with Thailand and Vietnam, three nights is a useful benchmark. If somewhere requires a significant journey to reach, give yourself enough time for the destination to justify that journey.

There are exceptions. A one-night stop in Yogyakarta might make sense as part of a tightly planned Java route, while a two-night Komodo boat experience can be the entire reason for travelling to Labuan Bajo. But repeatedly changing hotels every one or two nights is usually a warning sign.

The question isn't whether you **can** fit a destination into the itinerary. The question is whether the destination is worth the time required to reach it.

THINK IN CLUSTERS

One of the easiest ways to improve an Indonesian itinerary is to group destinations that naturally work together.

Bali + Lombok/Gilis is a straightforward island combination. You can experience Bali's culture and infrastructure before moving into a more relaxed beach-focused section.

Java + Bali creates one of the strongest cultural and landscape combinations. You can experience Yogyakarta and the major temples, travel through volcanic scenery and then finish in Bali.

Bali + Komodo works well when you want a classic Bali experience followed by a more adventurous few days around Labuan Bajo and the national park.

Lombok + Gilis is ideal when beaches and island life are the main purpose of the trip. There is little reason to add Bali simply because it is the country's most famous destination.

DON'T CONFUSE CLOSE WITH EASY

The distance between Bali and the Gilis looks small, but the actual journey involves getting to the departure point, waiting for the boat and then transferring to your accommodation. Weather and sea conditions can also affect boat services.

The same principle applies to Komodo. Labuan Bajo may be a relatively short flight from Bali, but a Komodo experience then involves organising boats, tours and transfers. It deserves enough time to make that effort worthwhile.

This is why your **transport plan should exist before your hotel bookings**. If the route depends on a particular flight or boat, check that connection first. Then build the accommodation around it.

THE ROUTE TEST

Before adding a destination, ask five questions:

What does this place add? How long will it take to reach? Is there another destination already on my route that provides a similar experience? Am I genuinely excited about going? And would removing it make the trip better?

That final question is the most important.

If you already have three beach destinations, adding another island probably isn't creating much variety. If you already have Bali and Lombok, adding another tropical island simply because it is highly rated may be unnecessary.

But if you've spent a week on beaches and suddenly add Java's volcanoes and temples, the contrast could make the entire trip better.

OUTBOUND TIP: Don't build an Indonesian itinerary by drawing lines between islands. Build it by creating **contrasts between experiences**.

A strong trip might move from temples to mountains, mountains to beaches, or busy streets to quiet islands. That creates variety without requiring you to constantly change location.

The best Indonesian itinerary is therefore not the one that visits the most islands. It is the one where **every move changes the experience enough to be worth the effort**.

Fewer islands. Better trips.

04 — BALI

Bali is the easiest place in Indonesia to build a varied first trip. Within one island you can move between temples, rice terraces, waterfalls, beaches, surf breaks, restaurants, nightlife and quieter rural areas.

The problem is that Bali's popularity can make it tempting to try to experience all of it in one trip. **Don't.** Bali is much larger in practice than it looks on a map, and traffic can turn relatively short journeys into long ones.

For most first-time visitors, **5–7 nights is a strong starting point**. Three or four nights can work if Bali is only one part of a wider Indonesia trip, while a week or more gives you enough time to combine different parts of the island without constantly changing hotels.

UBUD

Ubud is the natural base for experiencing Bali's cultural and inland side. The area is surrounded by rice terraces, temples, jungle landscapes and smaller villages, while the town itself has an enormous range of restaurants, cafés and wellness experiences.

Spend **at least two or three nights** if Ubud is part of your trip.

Use the first day to explore the town and surrounding temples, then use another day for the countryside or a specific experience. A sunrise hike, cooking class, cycling trip or visit to the rice terraces can work well depending on your interests.

Don't assume that staying in central Ubud means you're surrounded by untouched countryside. The centre is busy and highly developed. If the peaceful, tropical version of Ubud is what you're looking for, consider staying slightly outside the busiest streets while making sure you still have practical access to the places you want to visit.

OUTBOUND VERDICT: Ubud is worth including for **culture, food, nature and a slower inland experience**. It doesn't need to dominate the entire Bali itinerary.

THE SOUTH

Southern Bali offers a completely different experience. **Seminyak, Canggu, Uluwatu and the Bukit Peninsula** each attract different types of travellers, so don't treat "South Bali" as one destination.

Seminyak is well suited to travellers who want restaurants, beach clubs, shopping and convenience.

Canggu has a younger, more social atmosphere with cafés, restaurants, surf and nightlife.

Uluwatu and the Bukit Peninsula are stronger choices for dramatic coastal scenery, beaches and surfing.

If you're interested in surfing, Uluwatu deserves serious consideration. If nightlife and restaurants are more important, Canggu or Seminyak may suit you better. If you're looking for a more relaxed beach-focused stay, look beyond the busiest areas rather than automatically choosing the most famous town.

OUTBOUND TIP: Don't book accommodation in Canggu because someone told you it's the best place in Bali. Book it because you actually want the type of holiday Canggu provides.

TEMPLES & CULTURE

Bali's Hindu culture is one of the things that makes the island distinct from the rest of Indonesia. Temples and religious ceremonies are part of everyday life rather than simply tourist attractions.

Uluwatu Temple, Tirta Empul, Tanah Lot and Besakih are among the better-known sites, but you don't need to visit every temple on the island. Choose a few that fit your route and interests.

When visiting religious sites, dress appropriately and follow local instructions. Some temples require visitors to cover their shoulders or knees, and access can sometimes be restricted during ceremonies.

Remember that these are active places of worship, not simply attractions.

RICE TERRACES & NATURE

Bali's inland landscapes are one of the main reasons travellers visit Ubud and the surrounding region. Rice terraces, waterfalls, forests and volcanic landscapes create a strong contrast with the coast.

Tegallalang is one of the most accessible rice-terrace experiences near Ubud, while areas further from the centre can provide a quieter experience.

If you want photographs, go early and accept that popular locations will be busy. If you want the landscape itself, consider exploring less famous areas rather than chasing the most photographed viewpoint.

Mount Batur is another popular experience, particularly for sunrise. It can be worthwhile if you enjoy hiking, but don't book it simply because every Bali itinerary includes it.

HOW LONG SHOULD YOU STAY?

For a first Bali trip within a wider Indonesia itinerary, **5–7 nights** is a good range.

A simple structure could be three nights around Ubud followed by three nights in the south. This gives you a clear change of scenery without constantly packing and unpacking.

If you have longer, don't automatically add another hotel. Stay in one area for longer and explore further by day where practical.

If Bali is the **entire holiday**, you can comfortably spend 10–14 days exploring different parts of the island at a slower pace.

THE BIGGEST BALI MISTAKE

The classic mistake is trying to combine **Ubud → Canggu → Seminyak → Uluwatu → Nusa Penida → Nusa Lembongan** in a week.

Every destination might be good individually. The problem is that together they create a trip dominated by transfers.

Instead, choose the parts of Bali that match your priorities.

Culture and nature? Ubud.

Surf and dramatic coast? Uluwatu.

Restaurants and nightlife? Canggu or Seminyak.

You don't need to experience every version of Bali to have experienced Bali properly.

OUTBOUND RULE: Pick **two sides of Bali**, not every side of Bali.

The strongest Bali itinerary has a rhythm to it. Spend some time inland, then slow down by the coast. Follow a busy day with an easier one. Leave enough time to eat properly, wander and enjoy where you're staying.

Bali is not somewhere you need to conquer.

It's somewhere you should leave wishing you'd stayed a little longer.

05 — JAVA

Java is the part of Indonesia to choose when you want **volcanoes, major temples, cities and a stronger cultural contrast with Bali**.

It is much more than a route between Jakarta and Bali. Yogyakarta provides some of the country's most important cultural sights, while the volcanic landscapes around East Java offer a completely different side of Indonesia.

The main question is whether Java adds something you genuinely want.

If your ideal trip is beaches, relaxed island life and Bali's temples, you don't need to force Java into the itinerary.

If you're interested in history, architecture, mountains and adventure, however, Java can be one of the strongest additions you make.

YOGYAKARTA

Yogyakarta is the cultural heart of a classic Java itinerary.

The city has a strong connection to Javanese art, history and tradition, while the surrounding area contains two of Indonesia's most important temple complexes.

Give Yogyakarta **two or three nights**.

This provides enough time to explore the city, experience its food and culture, and visit the major temples without making the entire stay feel like a sightseeing mission.

The **Kraton**, or Sultan's Palace, provides an introduction to the city's royal heritage, while **Malioboro Street** gives you a much more energetic look at modern Yogyakarta.

The city is also known for batik, traditional arts and an excellent food scene.

The major reason many travellers come to Yogyakarta, however, is the temples.

BOROBUDUR

Borobudur is one of Indonesia's defining cultural landmarks and one of the strongest reasons to include Java in your itinerary.

The enormous Buddhist temple complex is surrounded by volcanic landscapes and is particularly atmospheric early in the day.

Don't treat Borobudur as something to rush through on the way to Bali. If you're making the journey to Java specifically for the temples, give yourself enough time to actually appreciate the site and the surrounding area.

Check current visitor arrangements before travelling, as access rules, opening times and ticketing arrangements can change.

OUTBOUND VERDICT: If temples, history and culture are important to you, Borobudur alone can justify adding Java.

PRAMBANAN

Prambanan provides a completely different architectural experience.

The Hindu temple complex is another major cultural site near Yogyakarta and works naturally alongside Borobudur.

The contrast between the two is part of what makes the combination worthwhile. You aren't simply visiting two similar temples — you're seeing two different religious and cultural traditions within the same region.

Allow enough time for both rather than trying to squeeze them into an already packed travel day.

MOUNT BROMO

East Java is where the itinerary becomes more adventurous.

Mount Bromo is one of Indonesia's most famous volcanic landscapes, and the experience is primarily about the scale of the scenery rather than simply standing at the crater.

The classic experience involves an early start to reach a viewpoint around sunrise before travelling into the volcanic landscape.

It can be spectacular, but the timing and conditions mean you should treat it as a proper experience rather than something to squeeze between two unrelated destinations.

If you're including Bromo, build the route around it. Don't assume you can finish a sunrise experience and immediately have a comfortable long-distance travel day afterwards.

OUTBOUND TIP: Volcano experiences are early starts. If you're doing Bromo, don't book the following day as though you've had a normal night's sleep.

JAVA OR BALI?

This is the decision many travellers should actually be making.

If you have **7–10 days**, Java and Bali together can become quite busy.

Choose Java if volcanoes, temples and culture excite you more than additional beach time.

Choose Bali if you want a broader combination of beaches, food, temples and relaxation with less movement.

With **two weeks or more**, combining Java and Bali becomes much easier.

A strong route could be **Yogyakarta → Bromo → Bali**, creating a natural progression from culture to mountains to island life.

You don't necessarily need Jakarta unless the city itself is something you're interested in.

HOW LONG SHOULD YOU STAY?

For a focused Java experience, **four to six nights** can work well.

Two or three nights around Yogyakarta followed by time around Bromo gives you a strong introduction without requiring an enormous amount of time.

If you want to explore further, Java can easily support a much longer trip. But for a first-time Indonesia itinerary, the objective isn't to see every major city and volcano.

It is to choose the experiences that create the most contrast with the other parts of your trip.

OUTBOUND RULE: Don't add Java because you feel your Indonesia trip needs more destinations. Add it because **you want what Java does differently**.

Java is at its best when it provides contrast. A few days among temples and volcanoes can make the beaches of Bali or Lombok feel even more rewarding afterwards.

06 — LOMBOK & THE GILIS

Lombok is what many travellers hope Bali will feel like: **beautiful beaches, fewer major tourist centres and more space to slow down.**

It isn't simply "Bali without the crowds", though. Lombok has its own character, with surfing, mountain landscapes, traditional Sasak culture and a much more relaxed rhythm in many areas.

The **Gili Islands** sit just off Lombok and are a natural extension of an island-focused itinerary.

But they aren't interchangeable.

Gili Trawangan, Gili Air and Gili Meno each have a noticeably different atmosphere, so choosing the right one matters more than trying to visit all three.

LOMBOK

Lombok is a strong choice if you want a combination of **beaches, surfing, nature and adventure.**

The south coast around Kuta is particularly attractive for travellers looking for beaches and surf without the scale of southern Bali.

The island also offers access to **Mount Rinjani**, one of Indonesia's major trekking experiences.

A Rinjani trek is a serious physical undertaking rather than a casual day activity, so if it is part of your plan, build the rest of your itinerary around it.

If you're not interested in trekking, you can still get plenty from Lombok.

Spend time around the beaches, explore the coastline, try surfing or simply use the island as a slower counterpoint to Bali.

OUTBOUND VERDICT: Lombok is particularly good for travellers who want **less intensity than Bali without sacrificing adventure or scenery.**

GILI TRAWANGAN

Gili Trawangan is the most social and lively of the three main Gili Islands.

It is known for nightlife, restaurants, bars, diving, snorkelling and a younger backpacker atmosphere.

If you're looking for parties and meeting other travellers, Trawangan is the obvious choice.

If you're looking for complete peace and quiet, it probably isn't.

OUTBOUND VERDICT: Choose Gili Trawangan for **social island life and nightlife**, not as your quiet escape.

GILI AIR

Gili Air sits between Trawangan and Meno in terms of atmosphere.

It has enough restaurants, bars and activities to keep things interesting, but generally feels more relaxed than Trawangan.

This makes it one of the strongest choices for couples, friends or solo travellers who want **beaches and island atmosphere without making nightlife the centre of the trip**.

Snorkelling and diving are major reasons to visit, and the island is small enough that you can settle into a simple routine of swimming, eating, walking and watching the sunset.

OUTBOUND VERDICT: If you're unsure which Gili to choose, **Gili Air is the best all-rounder**.

GILI MENO

Gili Meno is the quietest of the three and is better suited to travellers who want to switch off.

It has fewer restaurants and less nightlife, but that's precisely the point.

If your ideal island experience is reading by the beach, swimming, snorkelling and doing very little, Meno can be a better choice than the more famous Trawangan.

OUTBOUND VERDICT: Choose Gili Meno for **peace and relaxation**, rather than entertainment.

HOW MANY GILIS?

You don't need to visit all three.

In fact, moving between them simply to say you've visited each one is exactly the type of itinerary building OUTBOUND is designed to avoid.

Choose **one Gili** and stay long enough to enjoy it.

If you want a more varied Lombok trip, spend your time between Lombok and one Gili rather than hopping between all three.

LOMBOK OR BALI?

The choice depends on the holiday you want.

Choose Bali if you want more restaurants, nightlife, cultural attractions, established tourist infrastructure and a huge range of accommodation.

Choose Lombok if you want more space, beaches, surfing, nature and a slower pace.

You can absolutely do both.

In fact, **Bali + Lombok/Gili** is one of the easiest island combinations for a first Indonesia trip.

A strong structure might be **three nights in Ubud → three nights in southern Bali → four nights in Lombok or the Gilis**.

That gives you culture, beaches and a genuine change of pace without constantly moving.

OUTBOUND RULE: One island you properly experience is better than three islands you barely see.

If you're including Rinjani, adjust the route accordingly.

If you're focused entirely on beaches, you may not need both Lombok and a Gili.

If you're travelling with a group looking for nightlife, Trawangan may be enough.

If you're looking for relaxation, Air or Meno could make more sense.

The biggest mistake is choosing an island because someone says it is “the best”.

Choose the island that matches the holiday you actually want.

07 — KOMODO & LABUAN BAJO

Komodo is one of the experiences that can genuinely justify changing the shape of an Indonesia itinerary.

This is not simply another beach destination.

The combination of **Komodo dragons, dramatic islands, clear water, snorkelling and boat travel** makes the region feel completely different from Bali and Lombok.

The gateway is **Labuan Bajo**, on the western tip of Flores.

From here, boat trips head into Komodo National Park and the surrounding islands.

LABUAN BAJO

Labuan Bajo itself is primarily the base for exploring the surrounding area rather than the main attraction.

It has restaurants, hotels, dive operators and tour companies, but the reason to come is what lies offshore.

For most travellers, **two or three nights is enough** if you're using Labuan Bajo as a gateway to a boat trip.

If diving is a major priority, you can justify staying longer.

The important thing is to think about your boat trip **before booking your accommodation**.

Different trips have different departure times, durations and standards.

A cheap boat and a comfortable private or small-group experience can be very different holidays.

KOMODO DRAGONS

Seeing a Komodo dragon in its natural environment is the experience that makes this region unique.

The animals are wild, and visits to the islands are conducted with park guides and specific safety procedures.

Don't approach wildlife for a photograph or treat the animals like something you can interact with.

Follow your guide's instructions throughout the visit.

The dragons are obviously the headline attraction, but don't make the mistake of thinking the trip is simply a wildlife excursion.

The landscapes and marine life are equally important parts of the experience.

PADAR ISLAND

Padar is famous for its dramatic viewpoint overlooking several curved bays and contrasting beaches.

The hike to the viewpoint is relatively short but steep in places, and the heat can make it harder than the distance suggests.

If you want the classic view, an early start is worthwhile.

You'll avoid some of the strongest heat and potentially some of the crowds.

The viewpoint is spectacular, but don't judge the entire Komodo experience by one photograph.

The boat journey, smaller islands, beaches and water are what make the region feel special as a whole.

SNORKELLING & DIVING

The waters around Komodo are a major attraction in their own right.

Snorkelling can provide opportunities to see coral, tropical fish, turtles and other marine life, while diving offers access to a much wider range of underwater environments.

If you're primarily interested in diving, choose your trip around the **diving rather than simply adding Komodo sightseeing around it.**

Conditions, currents and dive sites vary, so use a reputable operator and make sure the experience matches your level.

For casual snorkellers, a well-designed boat trip can combine the marine experience with the major islands and viewpoints.

HOW MANY DAYS?

For most first-time visitors, **three nights around Labuan Bajo is a strong starting point.**

This can allow you to arrive, complete a full-day or overnight boat experience and have enough flexibility around the trip.

If you have only one night, you're creating a very tight schedule around a destination where weather and boat operations can affect your plans.

For a longer adventure, **two or three nights on a liveaboard** can turn the trip into something much more immersive.

This is particularly attractive if diving, snorkelling and being on the water are the main reasons you're coming.

WHEN KOMODO EARNS ITS PLACE

Komodo makes the most sense when you want something **genuinely different from Bali or Lombok**.

If you've already planned a week of beaches and island life, adding Komodo may not make sense simply because it is famous.

But if you want wildlife, dramatic landscapes and an adventure on the water, it offers something neither Bali nor Lombok can really replicate.

OUTBOUND VERDICT: Komodo is worth the logistical effort when it is one of the experiences you're most excited about.

THE KOMODO RULE

Don't treat Komodo as a box to tick.

Arrive with enough time to enjoy the boat experience, accept that conditions can affect the itinerary and choose your operator carefully.

A slightly more expensive, well-reviewed experience can be much better value than choosing the cheapest boat purely because it saves money.

OUTBOUND TIP: If your itinerary includes a boat trip, don't schedule a critical flight immediately afterwards. Give yourself a buffer in case weather or sea conditions affect the timing.

Komodo is one of those places where **the journey is part of the destination**.

That's exactly why it deserves a place on an Indonesia itinerary — **but only if you're willing to give it enough time to experience properly**.

08 — GETTING AROUND INDONESIA

Getting around Indonesia is relatively straightforward once you understand one thing: **you are often travelling between islands, not simply between cities**.

That means the journey can involve a flight, ferry, fast boat, road transfer or several of these in combination.

The cheapest option isn't always the best-value option, particularly when you have limited time.

DOMESTIC FLIGHTS

For longer distances, **flying is usually the most practical choice**.

Bali, Java, Lombok and Flores are spread far enough apart that trying to travel everywhere by boat or road can consume a large part of your holiday.

Flights make the most sense when they replace an entire day of surface travel.

On a 7–10 day itinerary, paying more for a flight can be one of the best uses of your budget because it gives you more time at the destination.

Don't look only at the flight duration.

Add the journey to the airport, check-in, security, baggage collection and transfer at the other end.

Even with those additional steps, flying is usually the sensible choice for genuinely long journeys.

OUTBOUND RULE: When you only have ten days, your transport budget should protect your holiday time.

FERRIES & FAST BOATS

Boats become much more important when travelling around **Bali, Lombok and the Gilis**.

Fast boats can make island-hopping convenient, but they also introduce variables that don't exist with a straightforward flight.

Sea conditions and weather can affect schedules, and journey times can be less predictable than the booking confirmation suggests.

Port transfers can also add considerable time.

If you're taking a boat before a flight, **leave a proper buffer**.

Don't design an itinerary where a delayed boat means missing an international flight.

TRAINS

Java is where trains become particularly useful.

The railway network connects many of the island's major destinations and can be an excellent way to travel between cities while seeing more of the landscape.

For journeys such as **Yogyakarta to Surabaya**, trains can offer a good balance between comfort, price and experience.

They can also be considerably more relaxing than spending the same amount of time in road traffic.

DRIVERS & PRIVATE TRANSFERS

Private drivers are particularly useful in places where public transport doesn't conveniently connect the sights you want to visit.

In Bali, for example, a driver can make it much easier to explore temples, rice terraces and other attractions without constantly arranging separate taxis.

For groups, splitting the cost can make a private driver surprisingly good value.

The key is to agree on **what is actually included** before travelling.

Confirm the number of hours, destinations, waiting time and whether fuel or parking is included.

Don't assume that a low headline price covers unlimited driving.

SCOOTERS

Scooters are one of the most common ways for visitors to get around parts of Indonesia, particularly Bali and Lombok.

They can be convenient and inexpensive, but they should not be treated as a compulsory part of the experience.

Traffic can be heavy, roads can be unfamiliar and conditions can change quickly.

If you're not an experienced rider, using a scooter simply because other travellers are doing it isn't worth the risk.

You also need to consider **licensing and insurance requirements**.

If you aren't properly equipped and experienced, use a driver, taxi or other transport instead.

THE HIDDEN COST OF MOVING

This is the biggest transport lesson in Indonesia.

Imagine that a fast boat between two islands takes only two hours.

That doesn't mean you've lost only two hours.

You may need an hour to reach the port, arrive early, wait for boarding, travel, collect your bags and then spend another hour reaching your accommodation.

Suddenly a "two-hour transfer" has taken half a day.

This is why **transport days need to be counted as part of the itinerary**.

If you move every two days, you're effectively spending a significant part of your holiday packing and unpacking.

HOW TO BOOK

Book the journeys that **your itinerary depends on** first.

International flights obviously need to be confirmed.

Popular domestic flights can also be worth booking in advance, particularly around busy periods.

Major boat journeys and specialist experiences should receive more attention if missing them would disrupt the rest of the route.

More flexible local transport can usually be arranged closer to the time.

Keep your important booking information accessible offline.

BUILD IN BUFFER

Indonesia is not a country where every connection needs to run perfectly.

If you're arriving on a boat and flying internationally the same evening, you've created unnecessary risk.

If you're travelling to a remote destination for a once-in-a-lifetime experience, don't schedule your arrival so tightly that one delay ruins the entire plan.

Give yourself **buffer where the consequences of a delay are high**.

OUTBOUND TIP: The cheapest route between two destinations isn't necessarily the cheapest route for your holiday.

Calculate the **total cost in money, time and hassle** before deciding.

The best Indonesian transport plan usually combines several methods.

Fly when the distance is large, use trains when Java makes them practical, use boats when the islands naturally connect, and use drivers or local transport when they make exploration easier.

You don't need to become an expert in Indonesian transport before you arrive.

You just need to make sure **the transport serves the itinerary rather than the itinerary being built around transport**.

09 — THE ROUTES

Indonesia is too large to have one “perfect” itinerary.

The right route depends on whether you want **culture, adventure, beaches, diving, nightlife or simply a slower island escape**.

These routes are designed around arrival and departure days, so a 10-day trip means Day 1 is your arrival day and Day 10 is your departure day — usually **9 nights**.

The most important rule is to **choose your route before booking individual hotels and activities**.

Once you've decided which experiences matter most, the rest becomes considerably easier.

7 DAYS — KEEP IT SIMPLE

With only seven days, choose **one island properly or two closely connected areas**.

Indonesia is not the place to attempt Bali + Java + Lombok + Komodo in a week.

OPTION A — BALI

For a first trip, seven days entirely in Bali is an excellent option.

Spend **three nights around Ubud** and **three nights in the south**, leaving Day 7 for departure.

Use Ubud for temples, rice terraces, food, countryside and culture.

Move south for beaches, surfing, restaurants and nightlife.

The contrast makes the trip feel varied without requiring flights or major island transfers.

This is probably the **best seven-day option for first-time visitors** who want a bit of everything.

OPTION B — BALI + LOMBOK/GILI

If beaches and island life are the priority, spend **three nights in Bali** followed by **three nights in Lombok or one of the Gilis**.

This gives you a clear change of pace: Bali for culture and exploration, followed by several days where the itinerary can become deliberately slower.

Choose **Gili Trawangan** for nightlife and social atmosphere, **Gili Air** for the best all-round balance, or **Gili Meno** for a quieter escape.

WHAT NOT TO DO: Bali → Lombok → Gili Trawangan → Gili Air → Gili Meno → Komodo in seven days.

You may technically be able to make the connections.

You won't have much of a holiday.

10 DAYS — THE OUTBOUND DEFAULT

Ten days gives you enough time to combine different sides of Indonesia without turning the entire trip into a transfer schedule.

OPTION A — BALI + LOMBOK

Days 1–3 — Ubud

Arrive in Bali and use the first three days for Ubud, temples, rice terraces, food and a slower introduction to the island.

Days 4–6 — Southern Bali

Move south and spend three nights around Uluwatu, Canggu or Seminyak depending on your priorities.

Use the time for beaches, surfing, restaurants and nightlife.

Days 7–9 — Lombok or the Gilis

Move across to Lombok or one Gili and spend the final three nights slowing down.

Day 10 — Departure

This route works because **Bali provides variety while Lombok/Gilis provides the change of pace**.

OPTION B — JAVA + BALI

If temples and volcanoes appeal more than additional beach time, spend the first part of the trip in Java.

Days 1–3 — Yogyakarta

Explore the city, Borobudur and Prambanan.

Days 4–5 — East Java / Bromo

Travel towards Bromo and experience the volcanic landscape.

Days 6–9 — Bali

Move into Bali and use the remaining time for Ubud and the south.

Day 10 — Departure

This is a much more experience-focused route than simply adding more islands.

You get **temples → volcanoes → Bali**, with each section feeling noticeably different.

OPTION C — BALI + KOMODO

For travellers who want a more adventurous trip, combine Bali with Komodo.

Spend **six or seven days around Bali**, then fly to Labuan Bajo for **three nights**.

Use the Komodo section for a boat trip, wildlife, snorkelling and the dramatic island landscapes.

This is particularly strong if Komodo is something you're genuinely excited about.

OUTBOUND VERDICT: At ten days, choose **two major experiences**, not five destinations.

14 DAYS — NOW YOU CAN EXPAND

Two weeks gives you enough time to combine several regions while still keeping the itinerary enjoyable.

OPTION A — CLASSIC INDONESIA

Days 1–3 — Yogyakarta

Start with Java's culture, food and temples.

Days 4–5 — Bromo / East Java

Experience the volcanic landscapes before continuing towards Bali.

Days 6–10 — Bali

Spend three nights around Ubud followed by two nights in the south, or reverse the order depending on your arrival and interests.

Days 11–13 — Lombok or the Gilis

Finish with three nights of beaches, surfing or island life.

Day 14 — Departure

This is one of the strongest two-week routes if you want **culture + adventure + Bali + beaches** without trying to see every major Indonesian destination.

OPTION B — BALI + KOMODO + LOMBOK

If beaches, wildlife and marine experiences are the priority, simplify the cultural side and build around the islands.

Days 1–5 — Bali

Combine Ubud with the south.

Days 6–8 — Komodo / Labuan Bajo

Fly to Labuan Bajo and spend several days around Komodo National Park.

Days 9–13 — Lombok or the Gilis

Finish with a slower island section.

Day 14 — Departure

This route creates a strong progression from **culture → adventure → relaxation**.

OPTION C — BALI DEEP DIVE

You don't have to leave Bali.

If you want a slower trip, spend the entire two weeks exploring different parts of the island without constantly changing countries, islands or hotels.

Use Ubud for inland culture, the south for beaches and nightlife, and additional time for quieter areas that suit your interests.

This can actually be a better holiday than trying to prove you've seen more of Indonesia.

OUTBOUND RULE: More days don't require more destinations. They can simply mean **more time in the destinations you've already chosen**.

21 DAYS — THE FULL EXPERIENCE

Three weeks gives you enough time to build a genuinely comprehensive first Indonesia trip.

A strong route could be:

Days 1–3 — Yogyakarta

Culture, food and the major temples.

Days 4–6 — East Java

Travel through the volcanic landscape and experience Bromo, with additional time if needed for the journey.

Days 7–11 — Bali

Three nights around Ubud followed by two nights in the south, or adjust the split depending on your priorities.

Days 12–15 — Lombok

Beaches, surfing, countryside and potentially Mount Rinjani if trekking is a major objective.

Days 16–18 — Komodo / Labuan Bajo

Boat trip, Komodo dragons, Padar and snorkelling.

Days 19–21 — Flexible finish

Return to Bali, extend Lombok, stay around Labuan Bajo or use the final days as recovery time before your flight.

This route is deliberately flexible at the end.

After three weeks of travelling between islands, **the final few days should not become another logistical challenge.**

WHICH ROUTE IS RIGHT FOR YOU?

If you want the easiest all-round first trip, choose **Bali + Lombok/Gilis**.

If you want culture, temples and volcanoes, choose **Java + Bali**.

If you want wildlife, snorkelling and dramatic landscapes, choose **Bali + Komodo**.

If you want beaches and island life above everything else, **Bali + Lombok/Gilis** is the strongest choice.

If you have three weeks and want the broadest experience, combine **Java + Bali + Lombok + Komodo**, but only if you're comfortable with the additional travel involved.

The key is not to make the longest route automatically the best route.

Before booking, look at every transfer and ask yourself:

Is this destination worth the half-day or full day it takes to reach?

If the answer isn't an immediate yes, remove it.

Your Indonesia itinerary should leave you wanting another week in the country. It shouldn't leave you needing a holiday when you get home.

OUTBOUND. Fewer places. Better trips.

10 — YOUR FINAL INDONESIA CHECKLIST

A good Indonesia trip is mostly decided by **what you choose not to do**.

The country has enough islands, beaches, temples, volcanoes and experiences to fill several holidays, so the final stage is about making sure the route you've built is realistic rather than trying to add one more destination.

BEFORE YOU BOOK

Decide what you actually want from Indonesia.

If beaches are the priority, don't let a long list of temples take over the trip.

If volcanoes and culture are what excite you, don't add three different islands simply because they're popular.

Your priorities should determine the route.

Check the weather for the **specific islands and regions** you're visiting.

Indonesia doesn't have one uniform climate, and conditions can matter particularly for boat trips, trekking and other outdoor activities.

Build the route before booking hotels.

Check every major transfer and work out how much of the day it will actually consume.

Remember that a two-hour boat journey may involve several additional hours of transfers and waiting.

Check the current **entry and visa requirements for your passport** before booking non-refundable travel.

Requirements can change, so use official Indonesian immigration information rather than relying on an old travel guide.

BEFORE YOU FLY

Make sure your passport meets the current entry requirements and that any required visa or arrival documentation has been arranged.

Take out travel insurance that actually covers your trip.

If you're planning to ride a scooter, trek Rinjani, dive, snorkel or take part in other adventure activities, check the specific conditions rather than assuming you're covered.

Have your first accommodation confirmed and keep the address available offline.

Download important booking confirmations, maps and transport information before travelling.

Carry a mixture of payment methods.

Cards are useful in developed tourist areas, while cash remains important for smaller businesses and more remote destinations.

YOUR ROUTE

Look at your itinerary from start to finish.

If you're changing islands every couple of days, ask whether each move genuinely improves the trip.

Make sure your arrival and departure days are realistic.

Don't schedule a major boat journey immediately before an important international flight.

If you're doing an early-morning volcano experience, don't schedule a packed travel day immediately afterwards.

If weather could disrupt an important activity, leave yourself some flexibility.

YOUR EXPERIENCES

Identify the **three experiences you absolutely don't want to miss**.

These should shape the rest of the itinerary.

For one traveller that might be sunrise at Mount Bromo, exploring Borobudur and relaxing on Lombok.

For another it might be surfing in Bali, diving around Komodo and spending a week on the islands.

There is no correct list.

The important thing is that your money and time are being spent on things you actually care about.

YOUR TRANSPORT

Check the major flights before committing to accommodation.

Confirm boat departure points and times.

Allow realistic transfer times.

Have a backup plan for important connections.

If you're hiring a driver, confirm what is included.

If you're riding a scooter, make sure your licence and insurance arrangements are appropriate.

Don't choose transport purely because it is the cheapest option.

YOUR PACKING

Keep your luggage manageable.

Island-hopping means moving between airports, ports, boats, cars and accommodation, and a huge suitcase becomes a burden quickly.

Pack lightweight clothing, comfortable walking shoes, swimwear, sun protection and something suitable for religious sites.

If you're heading into the mountains, add warmer layers.

If you're trekking, pack appropriately for the specific activity rather than assuming the whole country will be hot.

YOUR MONEY

Set a realistic daily budget before you leave.

Indonesia can be extremely affordable, but costs rise quickly when you add private drivers, domestic flights, premium accommodation, diving, boat trips and other experiences.

The best place to save is usually on things that don't materially improve the trip.

The worst place to save is on the experience you travelled halfway around the world to have.

THE FINAL TEST

Before you leave, look at your itinerary and ask yourself five questions:

Am I excited about every major destination?

Have I allowed enough time in each place?

Are the transfers realistic?

Have I protected the experiences that matter most?

Does this actually feel like a holiday?

If the answer to any of these is no, change the itinerary.

Remove something.

Add another night.

Fly instead of taking a long surface journey.

Choose one island instead of three.

Indonesia is not a country you need to conquer.

It's a country you should leave wishing you'd stayed longer.

OUTBOUND RULE: One incredible trip through Indonesia is better than three rushed holidays disguised as one.

OUTBOUND

Fewer places. Better trips.